Chapter 2 – Mythology of the Vedic Age

"One day at sunrise, after his morning ablutions in the waters of the Sarasvati, Srila Vyasadeva sat down to meditate. The great sage saw certain anomalies in the fiber of the millennium…He foresaw that the life of everything material would be cut short for lack of virtue."

(From the *Bhagavata Purana*)

The ancient Indians believed that before the dawn of creation, Lord Vishnu, the Preserver, slept in the Ocean of All Causes with a giant, many-hooded serpent as his bed. As he slept, a lotus sprouted from his navel in which was concealed Brahma, the god of Creation. During the day, Brahma creates our world and the creatures who live on it, and during the night, everything he made is absorbed back into him. When it is time for the world to be destroyed, Shiva will appear to wipe all of our world away.

This was the creation story of India's first major religious group whose beliefs would come to be recorded in the four Vedic texts. The Vedic religion, to which these and other archaeological artifacts relate, was an important part of ancient Indian culture as many as 6,000 years ago. Their texts were called the Rig-Veda, the Sama-Veda, the Yajur-Veda, and the Atharva-Veda. These works, originally passed from priest to priest by spoken word, weren't written down until about the 8th century BCE.

Throughout the four Vedas, a fantastic history of India is written, in which various pseudo-humanistic gods haphazardly create, destroy, and visit the earth to participate in a plethora of wars of justice. According to ancient beliefs, the Vedic gods were able to inhabit any of the three planes of existence: the universe, the earth, and the spaces in between. The central creation story as written in the Vedas includes far more detail after Brahma is born. One such tale is that of the god Indra, king of the utmost heavens, who became drunk on a special beverage called soma and then released all the rivers, rains, storms, and lightning of the world by slaying a dragon.

Modern India has a wealth of ancient artifacts from the Vedic people of that early era. Objects like clay pots, administrative seals, toys, and statues are highly prized in private collections and museums the world over. Though these items can tell us a great deal about early India, the language used on the seals has been lost to antiquity. Nobody knows how to decipher the strange lettering, but thankfully, like their neighbors the Egyptians, the